



12 Literary extract analysis in English B (HL)

Individual assessment · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

At Higher Level, students study two literary works in the target language, and a short extract from one of them forms the basis of part of the individual oral: the candidate discusses how the extract connects to one of the five course themes, commenting on content, language choices and the extract's significance within the work as a whole. Strong responses go beyond plot summary, engaging with why the author's choices, such as imagery, structure or register, support a thematic idea.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Model comment on a short invented extract describing a character returning to a childhood home: 'The extract's slow, detailed description of the empty rooms reflects the theme of identities, suggesting that the character's sense of self is tied to a place that no longer matches her memories of it.'

Quick check · multiple choice

In the HL individual oral literary discussion, what should a candidate prioritize over plot summary?

- A Listing every event that happens in the extract
- B Analysing how language and structural choices connect to a course theme
- C Reciting the extract from memory
- D Describing the physical appearance of the book

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Individual oral (HL) task: prepare a short spoken commentary on a two-paragraph extract, imagining one from a novel you have studied, in which a character hesitates before making an important decision. Connect the extract to the theme of identities, commenting on at least one specific language choice such as word choice, sentence length or imagery, then be ready to discuss the extract's role in the work as a whole. [30]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [30]

A strong spoken commentary includes:

- A brief statement of what happens in the extract, kept short since it is not the main focus
- A clear, specific link to the chosen theme, for identities: the hesitation reflects internal conflict about who the character wants to become
- Analysis of at least one concrete language choice, such as short, fragmented sentences mirroring the character's uncertainty, rather than a vague comment like 'the language is descriptive'
- A comment on how this moment matters to the work as a whole, e.g. it marks a turning point in the character's development
- In the follow-up discussion: specific references back to the extract and the wider work, using precise literary vocabulary such as imagery, tone or narrative voice rather than general statements

Quick check answer

B. The discussion rewards analysis of how the author's choices relate to a theme, not simple retelling of events.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English B guide (2018).

Original FagusED teaching material. Not an official IB publication; the sample scenarios and language are invented and generic.